
DUNGEON CRAWLER CHESS

RPG chess in the Dungeon Crawler Carl universe

Play the demo: www.dungeoncrawlerchess.com



A fan project. Not officially affiliated with or endorsed by Matt Dinniman or Dungeon Crawler Carl. Pending licensing.

WHAT IS IT?

Dungeon Crawler Chess is RPG chess set in the Dungeon Crawler Carl universe. It keeps the bones of traditional chess and adds a bigger board, a drafted roster of characters with unique abilities, a dice-driven mana system, and a chaotic AI that can crash the game at any moment. Today it's a playable fan-made web demo. The vision is a full 3D cross-platform video game.

THE BOARD

Played on an 11×11 grid instead of the traditional 8×8. The bigger board makes room for more strategy and for the expanded ability system.

Free placement. There is no fixed starting formation. Before the first move, each player sets up their own back rank (the 8 major pieces) and pawn rank (their 8 drafted pawns) however they want, so strategy starts before the first move. Tuck Carl into a corner behind his pawns, spread out across the full width, or park a pawn right next to the major piece it combos with.

The center square (F6) is the boss spawn point. Any piece standing there when a boss is summoned is permanently destroyed.

THE PIECES

Back line: moves exactly like traditional chess

- **Carl (King)** — 1 square in any direction
- **Donut (Queen)** — any distance in any direction
- **Mongo (Knight)** — L-shaped jump that leaps over pieces
- **Katia (Bishop)** — any distance diagonally
- **Samantha (Rook)** — any distance horizontally or vertically

Each side has 2 Mongos, 2 Katias, and 2 Samanthas. Carl and Donut are unique.

Pawns and the draft

Pawns move like chess pawns: one square forward (two on their first move), capturing diagonally. But every pawn is a character with its own ability. Before each game, each player drafts **8 of 20** from the roster below.

DICE AND MANA

- **Roll.** At the start of each turn, the player rolls 2 dice. Each die is mana for that turn.
- **Spend.** To use an ability, spend a die that meets or beats its cost. Then make your chess move.
- **Combined costs.** Bigger abilities are marked *combined*: they need both dice added together to reach the cost.
- **Bank a die.** Save one unused die in your bank for a later turn, or for a reaction ability on your opponent's turn (Quasar's Mediation, Katia's She Tank, Samantha's Miss Me?).
- **Limited uses.** Some abilities work only once or twice per game, and Donut's Puddle Jump has a 10-turn cooldown, so timing matters.
- **Modifiers.** Zev boosts dice rolls, Raul the Crab and Mordecai lower ability costs, and some AI cards push costs up or down.

THE PAWN ROSTER: DRAFT 8 OF 20

Character	Ability	Cost	What it does
Zev	Biggest Fan	3	All friendly dice rolls get +1 on your next turn.
Mordecai	Manager Benefit	Auto	When captured, leaves a ghost on his square for 3 full turns (nothing can enter), then respawns on your back rank. While within 1 square of Carl or Donut, their ability costs drop by 1.
Prepotente	Special Boy	4	Moves 2 squares forward this turn, including 2-square diagonal captures. While Carl is in check, he can move 2 squares in any direction.
Elle McGib	Frozen	5	Freezes one enemy piece within 5 squares for 1 full turn. It can't move or use abilities.
Imani	Suppress	4	One enemy piece within 2 squares loses its abilities for its next turn.
Candy Biggs	Gang Gang!	10 combined, 1/game	Converts one enemy pawn to your side for the rest of the game.
Louie	Air Strike	6 combined	Drops a 2x2 blocked zone within 4 squares (all 4 squares must be empty). No piece can enter it for 2 full turns.
Sledge	Body Guard	4	Becomes immovable and invulnerable for 2 full turns.
Stripper Anaconda	Gun Show	5	Pulls any one female piece, friendly or enemy, 1 square closer to Anaconda by the shortest route. Donut always counts as female.
Quasar	Mediation	6, banked die, reaction, 2/game	When a friendly piece other than Carl is about to be captured, both players roll 2 dice. If the defender wins by 2 or more, the piece is saved and the attacker is captured instead. Not while your Carl is in check, and never for a piece giving check.
Lucia Mar	Sic Em	3	Restrains one enemy piece anywhere on the board for 1 full turn.
Chris	Lava Surge	4	Lava covers Chris's square and one square on each side (horizontal or vertical) for 2 full turns. The squares must be empty and no enemy adjacent. Chris can't move while it burns.
Juice Box	Shapeshift	Copied cost +1	Gains the ability of any dice-cost pawn she captures and can fire it at its cost +1, once per turn cycle (not on the turn she captures). Loses it if that pawn is resurrected.
Florin	Suppressing Fire	6	Pushes one enemy piece up to 2 squares directly away from Florin, stopping early if blocked.
Ren	Indestructible	Passive	Can't be captured normally. Only the enemy Carl moving onto him, or Blood Magic, removes him. He can't capture.
Signet	Succubus	6	Pulls any one male piece, friendly or enemy, 1 square closer to Signet by the shortest route. Carl can never be targeted.

Character	Ability	Cost	What it does
Miriam Dom	Blood Magic	8 combined	Sacrifice an adjacent friendly pawn to resurrect a captured friendly pawn onto your back rank.
Orthrus	No ability	—	A two-square piece. Moves 1 square head-first or rotates 90°, and can't capture. Only major pieces can capture him, and his death is permanent.
Raul the Crab	Group Climax	7 combined	All friendly ability costs drop by 2 on your next turn.
Bad Llama	Lava Spit	4	Spits a 1×2 lava strip within 4 squares for 3 full turns; no piece can enter it. Bad Llama can't move that turn.

MAJOR PIECE ABILITIES

Each major piece has 3 abilities. The third is **Boss Event Only**: it can only be used during a boss fight, and its attacks deal 1 damage per hit.

Carl (King)

- **Leader** (all dice combined, 2/game) — Add your dice together into a pull distance and pull Donut, Katia, or Samantha toward Carl along that piece's own movement path. Carl still makes his normal move.
- **Plot Armor** (8 combined, 1/game) — Carl moves up to 3 squares in any King direction and can capture where he lands. He can't pass through pieces or end in check.
- **Jug-o-Boom** (4) **BOSS EVENT ONLY** — Throws a bomb up to 3 squares. Hits if the boss is on or next to the target square.

Donut (Queen)

- **Puddle Jump** (7 combined, 10-turn cooldown) — Hops any distance in a Queen direction, passing over every piece. Must land on an empty square, so it never captures.
- **Cockroach** (7 combined, 1/game) — Resurrects a random captured friendly piece onto an open square next to Donut.
- **Magic Missile** (5) **BOSS EVENT ONLY** — Fires up to 5 squares in a straight line. Hits if the boss is in its path.

Mongo (Knight)

- **Pet Carrier** (4) — Takes Mongo off the board. Release him later for free within 2 squares of Donut. If Donut is captured while he's stored, Mongo goes too.
- **Rampage** (8 combined, 1/game) — Captures every enemy piece along his L-shaped paths, not just where he lands (never the enemy Carl).
- **Gorefest** (4) **BOSS EVENT ONLY** — Attacks up to 2 squares from Mongo in any direction.

Katia (Bishop)

- **She Tank** (6, 2/game, reaction) — Stops one enemy piece from moving on its next turn. Use it on your turn, or as a reaction with a banked die.
- **Blitzed** (5) — One friendly piece skips its movement requirement this turn and can still use its ability.
- **I Need My Space** (3) **BOSS EVENT ONLY** — Pushes the boss 2 squares directly away from Katia. Any piece it's shoved into is permanently killed.

Samantha (Rook)

- **Slut Shame** (8 combined, 1/game) — Swallows an enemy pawn within 3 squares. It respawns next to Samantha after 5 turns. Orthrus is too big to swallow.
- **Miss Me?** (5, reaction) — Forces a reroll of dice in play: your own at the start of your turn, or your opponent's as a reaction with a banked die.
- **IWKYM** (6) **BOSS EVENT ONLY** — While next to the boss, holds it in place for 2 full turns (it can still take damage). Then Samantha returns to her back rank.

THE AI

The AI is always watching. Three dice combinations summon it, on any roll. That includes versus rolls, when both players roll to settle an outcome (like Quasar's Mediation roll-off), because it's meant to be chaotic.

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Each summon draws the top card of a shuffled 14-card deck, one copy of each card. Once the deck runs out, summons do nothing. A summon is ignored while another event is still playing out (a boss fight, a control swap, System Reset, or Main Character Syndrome).

THE AI CARD DECK: 14 CARDS

Card	Effect
Lottery Ticket	Roll a die. 1–3, Custard : reset one of your spent limited-use abilities. 4–6, Fireball : a random square is struck and its piece is permanently killed (it fizzles if Carl is there).
You a Bitch	If you have fewer pieces than your opponent, roll for a chance to resurrect one of your captured major pieces.
AI's Pet	All your ability costs drop by 1 this turn.
Dirty Tootsies	All your ability costs rise by 1 this turn.
System Reset	No abilities can be used by either player this turn.
Too Boring	Each player permanently loses one pawn, chosen by their opponent.
Main Character Syndrome	No pawns can move this turn, for either player.
Matt's Drunk Again	The players swap control of each other's pieces for 1 to 6 turns (one die roll).
Mana Toast	You must immediately reroll both of your dice.
What a Bitch	You receive an Insta-Kill Boss Card, usable during any boss battle.
Summon Rage Elemental	Summons the Rage Elemental boss onto the center square.
Summon Feral Goose	Summons the Feral Goose boss onto the center square.
Summon Emberus	Summons the Emberus boss onto the center square.
Summon Goblin Murder Dozer	Summons the Goblin Murder Dozer boss onto the center square.

BOSS EVENTS

- **Spawning.** A Summon card brings its boss onto the center square, permanently destroying any piece there. If a boss is already active, the new one waits and spawns the moment the first falls.
- **Cooperation.** While a boss is out, the war pauses: captures are disabled, pieces move only to get into position, and both players work together. Only Boss Event Only abilities can hurt it.
- **Movement.** After each full round, both players roll 1 die. The total picks a compass direction (2 N, 3 NE, 4 E, 5 SE, 6 S, 7 SW, 8 W, 9 NW); on 10 to 12 it stays put. The boss permanently kills any piece it lands on or passes through, Carl included.
- **Falling.** If a Carl dies during a boss fight, that player has fallen and the survivor fights on with both armies. If both Carls fall, the game is a draw. Checkmate can't end the game while a boss is out.

Boss	HP	Moves	Unique rule
Rage Elemental	6	1 square	A straight fight: wear it down with Boss Event attacks.
Feral Goose	Immune	2 squares	Immune to all attacks. Defeated only when pieces stand on all 4 corners and the center square at the same time.
Emberus	8	1 square	A 5-square cross. All five squares move together, and anything under them dies.
Goblin Murder Dozer	5	2 squares	Plows 2 squares per move and kills everything it passes through.

GAME SETTINGS

Before each game, players can switch **AI Summon**, **Pawn Abilities**, **Major Piece Abilities**, and **Boss Events** on or off, and pick a **light or dark theme**.

THE VISION

A cross-platform video game for PC and mobile, so you can play on your phone against someone on their computer. 3D isometric, with fully modeled characters, full animations including unique capture animations, and online multiplayer with casual and competitive modes. Later: more characters, skins, and a physical edition with collectible miniatures and themed boards.

ABOUT THE CREATOR

Joey Roberts, Miami, FL. Small business owner and huge DCC fan. Built the demo and the website over roughly 300 hours using AI coding tools. Not a game developer by trade, just someone who got obsessed with an idea and wouldn't let it go.

Play the demo and see the full project at www.dungeoncrawlerchess.com